

Week 6: Traditional Political Systems I

JSS1 Nigerian History — First Term Lesson Note (Deep-Dive Edition)

Introduction

Before colonial rule, Nigerian societies developed their own systems of government, suited to their cultures and ways of life. This week examines two very different systems: the centralized Yoruba kingdoms and the decentralized Igbo village democracy.

Yoruba Kingdoms: Oyo and Ife

The **Oyo Empire** was one of the most powerful Yoruba kingdoms, governed by a system of checks and balances:

Office/Body	Role
Alaafin	The king of Oyo, regarded as a sacred, powerful ruler
Oyo Mesi	A council of senior chiefs who advised the Alaafin and could check his power
Bashorun	The head of the Oyo Mesi, the most powerful chief after the Alaafin

This structure meant the Alaafin, though powerful, was not an absolute ruler — the Oyo Mesi could challenge or even remove a king who ruled unjustly. **Ife**, meanwhile, was led by the **Oni**, regarded as a spiritual and ceremonial figure of great importance among all Yoruba kingdoms, tracing descent from Oduduwa.

Igbo Village Democracy

Unlike the centralized Yoruba kingdoms, most traditional Igbo communities were **acephalous** (without a single central king). Instead, governance was shared among:

Institution	Role
Council of elders	Senior, respected members of the community who made decisions collectively
Age-grade system	Groups of people of similar age with shared responsibilities, such as community labour or defence
Title societies	Groups of accomplished individuals who had earned respected titles through achievement
Village assembly	A general meeting where community members could voice opinions on important matters

This system is often described as a form of **village democracy**, since decisions were reached through consensus and broad participation rather than the command of a single ruler.

Real-Life Application

The Oyo Mesi's power to check the Alaafin illustrates an early example of checks and balances in government, a principle still valued in modern governance today. Similarly, the Igbo tradition of

decision-making through councils and community consensus reflects democratic values still practised in many community associations today.

Vocabulary

Word	Meaning
Acephalous	Having no single head or central ruler
Checks and balances	A system where different bodies limit each other's power
Consensus	General agreement reached collectively by a group

Evaluation Questions

- 1 Who was the Alaafin, and what was his role in the Oyo Empire?
- 2 What was the Oyo Mesi, and what power did it hold?
- 3 Who was the Bashorun?
- 4 What title was given to the ruler of Ife, and what made this role significant?
- 5 What does “acephalous” mean, and how does it describe traditional Igbo society?
- 6 Name two institutions involved in traditional Igbo governance.
- 7 What was the role of the age-grade system in Igbo communities?
- 8 Compare the Yoruba and Igbo political systems — which was centralized, and which was decentralized?
- 9 Why might the Oyo Mesi's ability to check the Alaafin's power be considered an early form of checks and balances?
- 10 In your own words, explain why the Igbo system is sometimes called a “village democracy.”

(Week 7 is Midterm Break — no new content.)